



Set Up Your Own Forum Using phpBB

Clichéd as it may sound, we do live in the age of the social media. It is normal for humans to gather in groups and communities—offline, and online too. We love to debate, fuss, poke fun at, and to interact in just about every way, with others. This article demonstrates how to set up your own forum to do just this. I will also briefly explain how to quickly set up a Web server and a database server. Read on!

Before we begin, let's list the ingredients for this recipe. We need the following:

- A Web server—namely, Apache.
- A database server, MySQL.
- A server-side scripting engine called PHP. (In the early days, PHP stood for Personal Home Page; now it's a recursive acronym—PHP: Hypertext Preprocessor.)
- These three components will run on a Linux OS (Ubuntu 11.04, in our case).

Apache, MySQL and PHP together are referred to as an AMP set-up. AMP can run on Linux, Windows, BSD, etc. In our case, we will install and run them on Linux, so ours will be termed a LAMP (Linux-Apache-MySQL-PHP) set-up.

Then comes the CMS (Content Management System), which is a Web application built to manage content (in our case, discussions and posts on a forum). We will use phpBB (PHP Bulletin Board), which is designed specifically for forum set-ups. It's one of the best seamless forum CMSs out there—and to top it all, it's free and open source, so we can customise it to our heart's content.

Setting up AMP

Let's use our favourite package manager (mine is Synaptic) to install AMP:

- Click the Ubuntu button (new in 11.04, with Unity and all) and type '*synaptic*'; locate it and hit *Enter*.
- Search for '*apache*'.
- Select the Apache packages.
- Repeat this for PHP ("*php*") and MySQL ("*mysql*").
- Hit *Apply* to install the packages.

That should do it. We don't need to configure anything yet. To check the installation, open a Web browser, and navigate to '*http://localhost/*'. You should get an "It works!" page

Setting up phpBB

Head over to its site (links are at the end of this article), and download the software. It's a tiny zip file, not more than 2 MB—sweet things come in small packages! Extract the contents into a folder called '*phpbb*' (or any name of your choice) in */var/www*.

We now need to create a database for phpBB. Launch